

Psalms 16

My Chosen Portion

The Lord is the portion of mine inheritance
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Preserve me, O God: for in thee do I put my trust.*
- 2 *O my soul, thou hast said unto the LORD, Thou art my Lord: my goodness extendeth not to thee;*
- 3 *But to the saints that are in the earth, and to the excellent, in whom is all my delight.*
- 4 *Their sorrows shall be multiplied that hasten after another god: their drink offerings of blood will I not offer, nor take up their names into my lips.*
- 5 *The LORD is the portion of mine inheritance and of my cup: thou maintainest my lot.*
- 6 *The lines are fallen unto me in pleasant places; yea, I have a goodly heritage.*
- 7 *I will bless the LORD, who hath given me counsel: my reins also instruct me in the night seasons.*
- 8 *I have set the LORD always before me: because he is at my right hand, I shall not be moved.*
- 9 *Therefore my heart is glad, and my glory rejoiceth: my flesh also shall rest in hope.*
- 10 *For thou wilt not leave my soul in hell; neither wilt thou suffer thine Holy One to see corruption.*
- 11 *Thou wilt shew me the path of life: in thy presence is fulness of joy; at thy right hand there are pleasures for evermore.*

2 · CONTEXT

A “michtam” of David, Psalm 16 is a psalm of confident trust that moves from personal refuge, through rejection of idolatry, to deep satisfaction in God as one’s portion, and finally to hope beyond death. Peter and Paul both apply verses 8–11 to Christ’s resurrection (Acts 2:25–31; 13:35), reading David’s confidence as ultimately fulfilled in the Holy One whose body did not see corruption. Henry treats the psalm as a pattern of a soul wholly satisfied in God rather than in rival gods or mere self-sufficiency.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

Opening plea for preservation grounded in trust: “Preserve me, O God: for in thee do I put my trust.” A personal confession follows —“Thou art my Lord”—establishing the relationship on which everything else in the psalm rests.

Verse 3-4

Contrast between the saints in the earth, in whom David delights, and those who chase after other gods, whose sorrows multiply. He refuses even to take their names on his lips, a strong statement about guarding devotion from divided loyalty.

Verse 5-6

The Lord Himself is described as portion of inheritance and cup, the one who maintains David’s lot. The imagery of surveyor’s lines falling “in pleasant places” pictures a satisfying, God-given portion in life rather than envy of others’ apparent gain.

Verse 7-8

Gratitude for God’s counsel, even reflected in nighttime instruction (“my reins also instruct me in the night seasons”). Setting the Lord always before him, David finds stability: “because he is at my right hand, I shall not be moved.”

Verse 9-11

Confidence spills into the body and beyond death itself: heart glad, flesh resting in hope, because God will not leave the soul in Sheol nor allow His Holy One to see corruption. The psalm closes with the path of life, fullness of joy in God’s presence, and pleasures forevermore—words the New Testament applies to Christ’s resurrection and, through Him, to all who trust Him.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

True security and joy come from making the Lord Himself—not rival loyalties or self-effort—one’s chosen portion, a trust so deep it reaches even into confidence beyond death, fulfilled ultimately in Christ’s resurrection.

Application for life today.

Take inventory of “other gods” competing quietly for your devotion—achievement, approval, comfort—and consciously choose the Lord as your portion instead. Practice setting Him “always before” you through regular remembrance in ordinary hours, not

just crisis moments. And let Christ’s resurrection, the ultimate fulfillment of this psalm, anchor your own hope for the path of life and joy beyond the grave.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What “other gods” or rival sources of security most often compete for the place that belongs to the Lord alone?

2. How could you practically “set the Lord always before” you in a typical day?

3. How does Christ’s resurrection, fulfilling verses 9–11, strengthen your own hope for the future?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).